

Impact: Medium Difficulty: Easy Misuse risk: Low

WHY IT WORKS

Effort is often invisible to the people who benefit from it — when you name what you see, you close the recognition gap. This activates intrinsic motivation more reliably than outcome-based praise alone.

WHAT IT IS (AND ISN'T)

- Not a participation trophy — you are naming real labour you actually observed, not consoling.
- Not a substitute for addressing results — effort and outcome are separate conversations, and this is only one of them.
- It is making invisible work visible, out loud, before the next thing starts.

THE PAYOFF

How it lands: Working hard around you never feels like shouting into a void.

Principle: People do not burn out from hard work — they burn out from unwitnessed hard work.

What you gain

- Loyalty from people who feel seen rather than consumed
- Effort that continues because it visibly registers
- Early warning of overload — people tell you what things cost
- Teams that surface invisible work instead of hiding it
- Trust that survives hard feedback, because notice came first

Why most people fail at it

- They only look at outcomes, so the effort stays invisible to them.
- They acknowledge and immediately pivot to the next ask, cancelling the moment.
- They qualify it — 'took a while, but...' — and the qualifier is all that is heard.
- They save acknowledgement for annual reviews, months after it would have mattered.

CORE FORMULA

Notice the specific work -> Name it aloud -> Do not qualify

MINIMUM VIABLE MOVE

Name one piece of effort you noticed today that would normally go unacknowledged. Say it without qualifying it or immediately moving on.

BEST FOR

- Managing or leading people
- Motivating someone who is working hard but not being recognised
- Strengthening loyalty and trust
- Preventing burnout in yourself and others

METHOD, STEP BY STEP

1. Notice — Notice the specific work

Look for the labour behind the artefact: the preparation, the redrafts, the staying late, the problem quietly fixed. Outcome is easy to see; effort takes deliberate attention.

Outcome only: 'The demo went well.'

Effort seen: 'The demo went well because someone rehearsed the failure cases. I know who.'

2. Name — Name it aloud

Say what you saw, specifically, to the person who did it. Noticing silently is worth nothing to them — the acknowledgement only exists once it is spoken.

Generic: 'Good job on this.'

Named: 'You rebuilt that model three times to get it right. I want you to know I noticed.'

3. No qualifier — Do not qualify

No 'but', no 'although', no 'next time'. The moment a qualifier arrives, everything before it is deleted.

Qualified: 'Huge effort on this — although it really should not have taken that long.'

Clean: 'Huge effort on this, and it shows. That is the whole message.'

FIELD TIP

Acknowledge before you ask for the next thing.

The most common way effort gets erased is not silence — it is the instant pivot to what is still missing. Put one full sentence of notice between the delivery and your next request, and let it stand alone.

Situation: A report lands in your inbox at 11pm, thorough and unasked-for.

Don't: 'Thanks. Can you add a section on costs?'

Do: 'I can see tonight in this — the depth is obvious. Tomorrow I will have one addition to ask for.'

PHRASE BANK

Effort Acknowledgements · Naming the work

- "I can see how much work went into that."
- "That took real effort and it shows."
- "I noticed how much you put into this — I wanted to say it."
- "That was not easy and you did it anyway."
- "I know that took longer than it should have — and you still got it done."
- "The amount of care in that was visible."
- "That was a lot to carry and you handled it."
- "I saw what went into this. I did not want to let it pass."

Specific Effort · Naming the particular thing

- "The preparation you put into that meeting was clear."
- "You did not have to go that far — and you did."
- "That was more thorough than it needed to be, and it made the difference."
- "You stayed through the hard part without cutting corners."
- "I noticed you did X even though nobody asked you to."

Quick Acknowledgements · Brief notice in passing

- "I saw the hours in that. Thank you."
- "That was a slog and you did it well."
- "Nice work staying on that until it cracked."
- "I know that was not fun. It mattered."
- "You carried that one. Noted."
- "That took patience I do not have. Thank you."

Professional Acknowledgement · Naming the labour in work settings

- "Before we review the outcome, I want to acknowledge the work rate that got us here."
- "The reason this migration felt uneventful is that months of preparation made it uneventful."
- "The polish on this did not happen by accident — someone gave up their evenings for it."
- "I want the effort behind this minuted, not just the result."
- "This ran smoothly because of preparation nobody saw. I saw it."
- "Whatever the outcome of the pitch, the quality of the preparation was exceptional."

Effort Repairs · When the work went unacknowledged

- "I went straight to feedback yesterday and skipped over the work itself. That was wrong — the effort was enormous."

- "I have been taking your reliability for granted. I want to stop doing that."
- "I realise I have never actually said this out loud: I see how much you carry."
- "My criticism landed before my acknowledgement. Let me reverse the order."
- "You have been doing the invisible work for months and I let it stay invisible. I am sorry."
- "The result got all my attention and the effort got none. That was unfair."

WEAK -> BETTER -> BEST

1. Weak: Moving straight to the next task without acknowledgement
Better: Good work on that.
Best: I know how much work went into that. I did not want to move past it without saying so.
2. Weak: Generic praise: 'You worked so hard!'
Better: That was a demanding piece of work.
Best: The preparation you put into that presentation was clear — especially under that timeline.
3. Weak: Backhanded acknowledgement: 'Finally got there!'
Better: It took a while but we got there.
Best: Clean acknowledgement of the effort, no qualifiers.

DECISION TREE

If Someone finishes a difficult piece of work

Acknowledge the work before moving to the next item.

"Before we move on — I want to say that took real effort and it shows."

If Someone is doing invisible work that goes unnoticed

Name it specifically and without prompting.

"I noticed you have been doing X — that does not go unnoticed."

If You want to acknowledge effort but do not want to sound patronising

Keep it simple and specific. One sentence. No fuss.

"That took a lot. I wanted to say so."

If The result was good but the effort was exceptional

Acknowledge the effort separately from the result.

"The result speaks for itself — but I also wanted to name what it took to get there."

SCENARIOS

Team member delivers after a difficult sprint

Name the effort before moving to what comes next. — "Before we get into the next phase — I want to acknowledge what that just took."

Colleague going through a hard period personally while maintaining output

Name the effort without making it about the personal situation. — "I see what you are carrying right now. I wanted to say it."

Peer who quietly fixed a problem nobody else noticed

Name the specific invisible work. — "I noticed you sorted that out on your own. That is the kind of thing that keeps things working."

Child or young person who tried hard regardless of outcome

Acknowledge the trying, not just the result. — "I saw how hard you worked on that. That matters more than the score."

WORKED EXAMPLE

Without the technique

Team member: (submits thorough, time-intensive analysis)

You: Thanks. Can you add one more section?

(Team member quietly deflated; effort went unnoticed)

With the technique

You: Before I ask for the addition — the depth of this analysis is clear. I can see the hours that went into it.

Team member: Thank you. That means a lot. What's the additional section?

COMMON MISTAKES

The pivot acknowledgement

Sounds like: 'Great effort — so, next steps...'

Better: Let the acknowledgement be its own sentence, with air after it, before any next thing.

The deleted compliment

Sounds like: 'You worked really hard on this, but...'

Better: 'You worked really hard on this.' Full stop. The feedback gets its own conversation.

Praising effort to dodge a performance problem

Sounds like: 'Well, at least you tried really hard!'

Better: Name the effort honestly and address the result separately — one does not cancel the other.

Acknowledging only the loud work

Sounds like: Praising the presenter, never the person who built the deck

Better: 'This ran because of preparation most people never saw. I saw it.'

The annual-review acknowledgement

Sounds like: 'Looking back at Q1, I note strong commitment levels.'

Better: Say it in the week it happens. Recognition has a half-life.

READING THE ROOM

Signs it is working

- People seem surprised — in a good way — that you noticed.
- Morale and motivation visibly improve.
- Trust builds faster than usual.
- The work continues at the same level or improves.

Signs to adjust

- Acknowledgements feel frequent enough that they lose meaning.
- You are acknowledging effort as a management tactic, not genuinely.
- The person feels patronised rather than seen.
- You are acknowledging effort while ignoring a real performance problem.

WHEN NOT TO USE

- When the effort was poor and naming it implies the outcome is acceptable.
- When managing underperformance — naming effort can inadvertently reward the wrong behaviour.
- When your acknowledgement would be read as performative because no real follow-through is planned.

RECOVERY LINES

Best line: 'I have noticed your work for months and said none of it out loud. That changes now.'

- "I moved straight to the next task and skipped what that took. Let me not do that."
- "I qualified that acknowledgement, which undid it. The first half was the true half."
- "I have noticed your work for months and said none of it out loud. That changes now."
- "That sounded like a managerial technique. It is not — I genuinely saw what that cost you."
- "I praised the result and ignored the sixty hours inside it. The hours deserved naming."
- "I acknowledged everyone except the person who did the quiet part. That is being fixed."

TECHNIQUE CHAINS

Deliver-then-ask chain

Name the effort -> let it land -> separate beat -> make the next request

Before anything else — the amount of work in this is obvious, and it did not go unnoticed.

(Pause. Let it be received.)

Now, when you have capacity, there is one more section I want to ask about.

No urgency on it — the main thing today was the first thing I said.

Invisible-work chain

Spot the quiet fix -> name it specifically -> say why it matters -> make it visible upward

I noticed the backlog did not fall over last week. That was you, quietly, wasn't it?

That is exactly the kind of work nobody sees and everybody depends on.

I have mentioned it to Priya, because it should not stay invisible.

Thank you. Genuinely.

RELATED TECHNIQUES

TC006 — Genuine Specific Compliment

Genuine Specific Compliment is the sibling — it praises the quality of the work; this card honours what the work cost.

TC025 — Shared Credit

Shared Credit takes the acknowledgement public — naming whose effort carried the result in front of the people who matter.

TC014 — Validate the Concern

Validate the Concern applies the same move to feelings — acknowledging what is real for someone before moving to what happens next.

7-DAY PRACTICE DRILL

Day 1 — Notice before speaking

In one interaction today, pause before moving to the next topic and ask: 'Did I acknowledge what just happened?'

Day 2 — The specific naming

Give one acknowledgement that names the specific work rather than just 'good job.'

Day 3 — Invisible work

Acknowledge one person doing work that nobody else is noticing.

Day 4 — Effort vs outcome

Practise separating acknowledgement of effort from assessment of result.

Day 5 — No qualifier

Give one acknowledgement with no 'but', no 'although', and no 'next time' after it.

Day 6 — Written acknowledgement

Send one short message to someone acknowledging a specific effort.

Day 7 — Calibration

Did acknowledgements land well? Were any too vague? Did any feel like performance rather than genuine notice?

AFTER-ACTION CHECKLIST

- Did I notice the effort before commenting on the result?
- Did I name the specific work — not just 'good job'?
- Did I say it without qualifying or immediately pivoting to the next ask?
- Was my acknowledgement genuine, not performative?
- Did I give the acknowledgement at the right moment — not too late?
- Did I acknowledge invisible or low-profile work that would normally go unnoticed?
- Did it land as genuine rather than managerial technique?